CHAPTER 6 · DEEP DIVE · HOUSE & DIVIDED

The Election of 1860

A four-way race that a man could win without a single Southern vote — and break the Union by winning. 1860.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

A four-way race that a man could win without a single Southern vote — and break the Union by winning. 1860.

How can someone become president with only 40% of the vote and no support in half the country — and why did that terrify the South?

Four Men, One Office

THE PARTIES SPLIT

By 1860 the Democratic Party — the last national party holding North and South together — split in two over slavery. The result was a chaotic four-way race.

Abraham Lincoln (Republican) opposed slavery's spread. Stephen Douglas (Northern Democrat) stood for popular sovereignty. John C. Breckinridge (Southern Democrat) demanded federal protection for slavery. John Bell (Constitutional Union) just wanted to avoid the question entirely.

1860 campaign cartoon — lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

“The National Game”

A NATION COMING APART

Cartoonists saw it clearly: the candidates tearing the country apart between them.

1860 campaign cartoon — lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

Two Separate Contests

A SECTIONAL ELECTION

It was really two elections at once. In the North, the race was Lincoln vs. Douglas. In the South, it was Breckinridge vs. Bell. Lincoln's name wasn't even printed on the ballot in most Southern states.

That split doomed the South's cause. With the free states holding more people — and more electoral votes — a candidate who swept the North could win the whole election while losing the entire South.

“The National Game. Three ‘Outs’ and One ‘Run’” — Currier & Ives, 1860, public domain (Library of Congress).

“Three ‘Outs’ and One ‘Run’”

THE CONTEST AS A GAME

Lincoln (right) wins the game while his three rivals strike out — an 1860 cartoon using America's new pastime, baseball.

"The National Game. Three 'Outs' and One 'Run'" — Currier & Ives, 1860, public domain (Library of Congress).

Winning Without the South

NOVEMBER 6, 1860

Lincoln won a clear majority of the electoral college while taking only about 40% of the popular vote — and not one Southern state.

The math that elected him was the same math the South had feared for a decade: the free North, voting together, now outweighed the slave South. To white Southerners, the rules of the game had just made them permanently powerless.

John C. Breckinridge — photograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Point of No Return

WHY IT MATTERED

Lincoln had promised only to stop slavery from spreading, not to abolish it where it existed. It didn't matter. His election proved the South could be outvoted on slavery by a North that didn't need it.

Six weeks after the vote — before Lincoln had even taken office — South Carolina began the march out of the Union. The ballot box had done what thirty years of argument could not: it had convinced the South there was no future for it inside the United States.

1860 campaign cartoon — lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

Read the Returns

YOUR TURN

You'll analyze the actual 1860 results like a data historian — figuring out how the numbers and the map produced a winner almost no Southerner voted for, and why that broke the country.